



free will
and
determinism

against
compatibilist
free will

A large red circle with a slight drop shadow, containing white text. The text is arranged in three lines, centered within the circle.

**against
incompatibilist
free will**

This argument seems to show that the combination of four theses — that No one has any choice about the past, no choice about the laws of nature, the no choice principle, and determinism — rules out free will.

Since the first three of these theses seem quite plausible, the argument seems to show that if determinism is true, there are no free actions — and hence that free will is incompatible with determinism.

1. Free will is incompatible with determinism.
 2. If Libertarianism is true, then there is no free will.
-

C. There is no free will.

The master argument against the reality of free will

Real/|the master argument:

The consequence argument is a defense of premise (1). If you believe in free will, and find the consequence argument persuasive, it looks tempting to reply to the master argument by denying premise (2).

But, we'll see now, this argument can also be given a plausible defense.

One way to introduce this defense is with the following quote from

David Hume:

Hume's basic thought is that there is a big difference between free actions and actions which are random or chance.

Here's a thought experiment:

Now ask yourself: is Alex's choice free? It seems very clear that it is not. It is undetermined by facts prior to the relevant run of the Randomizer, but it is random. It is not up to Alex what he does; and free actions have to be up to the person doing the action.

This suggests:

But now consider the idea that free will requires the falsity of determinism. If this is true, then it must be that free actions (or their immediate causes) are undetermined:

But consider what an undetermined act would be. It would be an action which is such that the entire history of the universe up to that point is consistent with the act either happening or not happening. So if the act happens, nothing **makes** it happen. In particular, nothing that the person who does the action, or anyone else, does makes the action happen.

One way to state the conclusion of the control argument is that free will
requires determinism.

1. If Libertarianism is true, then, if there are free actions, those actions are undetermined by anything prior to the action.
2. If an action is undetermined, then the agent does not control whether it happens.
3. If Libertarianism is true, then, if there are free actions, the agent does not control whether they happen. (1,2)
4. If an act is free, then the agent must control whether it happens.

C. If Libertarianism is true, then there are no free actions. (3,4)

THE CONTROL ARGUMENT



happened in the distant past.

future is not as it was with the state of the

of interest.

choice about DECISION (2, 6, 7)



2. None has any choice about DIDS ATJR.

1. No one has any choice about events which

varlatatie + the last of the

then DECISION. (4,5)

3. If determined, the only one

4. If determinism is true, the laws of

5. No one has any choice about what the laws

6. If $\det A$ is true, then A has any

C. If determinist is true, then no one has any

~ If none has about choice about whether P,

then DECISION happens. (3)

nature say that if DINS ARE happy,

if P , then Q , then one has any choice



theorie about the fact that if DNR

about whether @.

and none has any choice about whether,

choice about the laws of nature, then no



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actions are undertaken by

if there are if ree are act i o n s , t h o s e

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2. If an action is undetermined, then

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3: If Libertarian is true, then,



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C: If Libertarian is true, then



reality of free will.

We can lay out this puzzle in terms of the following master argument against the

Compatibility believers in free will reject premise (1). An incompatibilist

believe in free will rejects premise (2).

Now, so far we have been given no reason to think that either premise (2)

or premise (3) is true. We're now going to look at two arguments — one

for (2), and one for (3).

A large orange circle with a subtle drop shadow, containing the text "against compatibilist free will" in white, bold, sans-serif font.

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The master argument against the reality of free will



3. If Libertarians are right, then, if there

raindrops. (1,2)

no free actors.

underrated.

raindonin.

C. If Libertarianism is true, there are

are free actions, those actions are

4. Norms are free.

1. If Libertarianism is true, then, if there

2. If a and a' are indicated, then it is







c. There is no fire will.



2. If Libertarianism is true, there is no free

1. Freewill is incompatible with determinism.

Wili.



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One way to state the conclusion of the control argument is that free will